I found out that one of the officers on the coach with us was a science-fiction fan. He didn't know who I was, so I asked him leading questions, while the other six listened with straight faces, and finally elicited from him the fact that he read and liked Asimov's stories. After I got him to say that Asimov was "a brilliant fellow," I revealed myself.

It was funny at the time and for the moment, but it was a bad move. That was one officer who disliked me intensely thereafter—and it served me right. (Fortunately, he never did anything about it.)

On March 5, we stopped at Ogden, Utah, where I bought a postcard to which was attached a small pack of salt from the Great Salt Lake, and mailed it off to Gertrude. I usually got newspapers wherever we stopped so that I had a chance to read a wide variety in the course of the trip. The only one I specifically mentioned in my diary was the Salt Lake Tribune, which I called "rotten reactionary."

On March 6, we got off the train and took another to Camp Stoneman, California. I couldn't reach Gertrude that evening; the lines were all busy. The next morning I sent a telegram, which cost $.45, and, after trying all afternoon, finally put through a station-to-station call to her for $2.50 and heard her voice.

On Saturday, March 9, 1946, we embarked on a troopship called the President Hayes, which was going to take us on our second leg of our trip, and disembark us at Hawaii. That trip was to take us six days, and the President Hayes was no luxury liner. (This was to be my first ocean trip since I arrived in the United States twenty-three years before.)

There were about two hundred of us sleeping in the same room, with beds stacked three high. (I got an upper and was delighted to get it to myself.) It was so crowded that after waiting in the chow line for what seemed an interminable period, we gave up on dinner.

It was just as well. Once we got under way, seasickness was endemic. I didn't feel great, but I fought it down. I didn't throw up once, but considering that there were soldiers throwing up all about me, there seemed little advantage to not doing it. Everything smelled just as bad as though I were personally involved.

I decided to grow a beard for the duration of the ship voyage, together with mustache, through the simple expedient of not shaving. It was my third attempt at facial hair. By the time we disembarked, I looked like a western